
Jules Massenet

1842–1912, FRENCH

The most successful French operatic composer of the Belle Epoque, Massenet was admitted to the Paris Conservatoire at the age of 11. His winning the Prix de Rome in 1863 financed a stay in Italy, where he met Nino de Gressy, whom he married in 1866. Working tirelessly, he earned a living in Paris as a piano teacher while composing a stream of operas. His first stage work, *La Grand'Tante*, was produced in 1867, but he did not achieve significant commercial success until the mid-1870s. In 1878, he was appointed to a teaching post at the Conservatoire, which he held for almost 20 years. First staged in 1884, his opera *Manon* was the greatest success of his career, although many critics consider *Werther* (1892) a finer work. His marriage was troubled by involvements with the American soprano Sibyl Sanderson and later with the French mezzo-soprano Lucy Arbell. He continued to write tuneful operas with supreme fluency up to his death in Paris in 1912.

KEY WORKS: *Le Roi de Lahore* (opera), 1877; *Manon* (opera), 1884; *Werther* (opera), 1892; *Don Quichotte* (opera), 1910